

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Evacuation

EVACUATION SHELTER / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Leave a threatened location while a safer route and destination are still available. Take people, pets, essential medicines, identification, shoes, water and phone power; do not delay for belongings. Confirm the route and a place to stay, tell a trusted contact, and avoid flooded, closed or actively dangerous roads. Do not wait for an order when immediate danger is evident. Radiation or airborne hazards may make sheltering safer than travel.

Do now.

**Confirm the order**

01

Check the official zone, deadline, route, shelter options, and whether the order includes your address.

**Gather people first**

02

Account for everyone and pets. Take required medication and medical supplies, documents, accessible equipment, keys, and a charged phone. Do not spend critical time packing extras.

**Choose a destination**

03

Go to a trusted contact or designated shelter outside the hazard area. Check pet rules, accessibility, and transport needs.

**Leave and report safely**

04

Use current official routes. Share your destination with an out-of-area contact, keep fuel in the vehicle if relevant, and do not return until authorities say it is safe.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Choose a reachable destination with someone you trust, identify a second route, and agree on a check-in. Do not wait for transport that has not been confirmed. If the route is actively dangerous, compare the specific hazard of staying with the hazard of moving; shelter while reassessing if no safer route is available.

Watch for.

If a route is unsafe, do not force it. Follow current local instructions or contact emergency services for help. Some hazards, especially radiation fallout, can make immediate travel more dangerous than sheltering; follow the hazard-specific order.

People & practical needs.

Give dependents a written contact card and agree who stays with each person. Keep essential medicine and mobility equipment accessible. A pet carrier or heavy bag must not block a caregiver from helping someone move.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Make two destinations and more than one route in advance. Keep a small grab list by the door, especially for medications, pets, and items that cannot be prepacked.

Check the next usable option

Make two destinations and more than one route in advance. Keep a small grab list by the door, especially for medications, pets, and items that cannot be prepacked.

When the first option is unavailable

Choose a reachable destination with someone you trust, identify a second route, and agree on a check-in. Do not wait for transport that has not been confirmed. If the route is actively dangerous, compare the specific hazard of staying with the hazard of moving; shelter while reassessing if no safer route is available.

Questions in the field.

Is the destination usable?

Confirm the place can be reached and used by the people traveling: opening, access, medical power, pets and sleeping needs. A location on a map is not a promise of admission. Keep a second realistic option and a meeting point if the group separates.

The vehicle is unavailable - what changes?

Reassess safe reachable shelter, a trusted transport contact or a checked pedestrian route. Do not walk into floodwater, smoke or other moving hazards to preserve the original destination. Carry only what the least mobile person and helpers can manage.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov · Evacuation](https://www.ready.gov/evacuation)

<https://www.ready.gov/evacuation>

[Ready.gov · Make a plan](https://www.ready.gov/plan)

<https://www.ready.gov/plan>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/evacuation/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.